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Culture (OWC): [Gikuyu \(FL10\)](#)

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Sub Region: Eastern Africa

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Section Title(S): 6 Wangeci's Story: A Widow Among Women

At times, young girls come here and ask me questions that we would have never asked an older woman—like how one becomes pregnant. I tell them one has to wait and see for herself. And if a girl gets pregnant, the only thing I can advise her is never to take abortion tablets, for if you take them you will surely die. Now younger women are getting two or three children, but they come close together. Us, we would get the number one was able to get, but we never got another until the smallest one was three or four years and able to be a little independent—until it was weaned. We would space them out that way.

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Even if we tried to change back to the old ways, everything would go up in the air—it would have no meaning. In my time, one's *riikamates* were important, but today *mariika* have no importance to younger women. For us, they still have meaning. Like the woman called Wambaca in Karaini that went for *Irua* with me, we still help each other. If I'm in any need I call her, and she gathers people and comes to help me in the *shamba*. When my daughter got married she paid for most of the photos taken, and when her sons get married I will help her with the same. She also came and helped me with preparations for my daughter's wedding—like what to cook and buying the gifts. Sometimes, we give advice to each other when one knows more than the other. Like after my husband died, Wambaca came and said, "Now that your husband is dead, if I were you, I would not have another child by any other man and would only look after the ones your husband left." So I felt advised. But now, a younger woman will talk and joke with a man—even a younger one. In our case, those who were younger than us, if we met with them, we had our own way of greeting them that showed the separation between our ages. Now, it is different.

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After *Irua*, I stayed for only one year before I got my first menstrual period. Because I was not at my father's home, I got a handful of soil and went and threw it under my bed at home. *Cūcū* had told me that when one was expecting menstruation, her body would start feeling tired and lazy, and after

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a day or two one would see a flow of blood. If that happened at another girl's homestead and not hours, I should take a handful of soil from that girl's homestead and go throw it under her bed at her home to make it appear that I had started menstruating at home and not at another's.

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